In April Shuja marched his troops through the Bolan Pass, and as agreed Ranjit Singh moved north-west from Lahore, the armies of the Sikh Khalsa providing a diversion by crossing the Indus at Attock and taking Peshawar. The troops of the Barakzais, divided between the two fronts, could offer effective opposition to neither invading army. Everything for once was going to plan. Shuja now wrote to Wade in triumph, barely able to conceal his excitement. He ridiculed the Amirs of Sindh, 'these short-sighted people who forget that I am under special protection of God', and expressed optimism that victory over the Barakzais was near: 'By the divine favor, victory will continue to open her gate for me.'[89]

Only in May 1834, when Shuja's troops finally marched into the Kandahar oasis, did his run of luck begin to fail. The Barakzais had had time to prepare for his arrival and, by the time Shuja marched up to the city walls, supplies had been laid in and the city's defences were ready to withstand a lengthy siege. Moreover, Shuja's troops had little experience in siege warfare, and insufficient training, artillery and equipment to carry out an escalade on the city walls. 'The besieging forces had attacked the city unsuccessfully with heavy losses,' wrote Mirza 'Ata.

> Now they tried to scale the Fort walls at night with scaling ladders. These they carried in furtive silence in the dark to below the walls, and waited for sleep to disarm the watchers within. Then they planned to erect the ladders and storm the unsuspecting citadel. Sleep however attacked the royal besiegers first . . . At sunrise the King, impatient of news of the attack, and hearing no uproar from within the fort, had the reveille cannon fired. The besiegers suddenly awoke from their sleep, saw that the sun was rising and that the guards on the Fort walls were already awake and raising the alarm – but from fear of His Majesty, the besiegers went ahead and raised their ladders and swarmed up them, only to be met by a barrage of fire, to be thrown off the ladder of life into the ditch of death.[90]

After two months, the siege had become a stalemate, with both sides holding firm in their positions. It was at this point that news arrived that Dost Mohammad was approaching with 20,000 Barakzai troops from Kabul to aid his besieged half-brothers within the walls. Although Shuja had great numerical advantage – some estimates talk of his army having now swelled to 80,000 – he was anxious that Dost Mohammad might cut off the water supply to his troops, so he fell back from his safely entrenched position in front of the city walls to a well-watered belt of gardens along the Arghandab River to the north-east. Hearing this, Dost Mohammad rode ahead on his own to investigate. 'When the Dost got wind of this retreat, he